

Little Known Facts of the Lewis and Clark Expedition

by Dr. H. Carl Camp



The Mishap at Brunot's Island

Events attending the launch of the Lewis and Clark Expedition were not all that auspicious. Meriwether Lewis had spent the last few weeks of July and all of the month of August, 1803, cooling his heels in Pittsburgh while fretting and fuming over the repeated failures of his alcohol-besotted boat-builder

to deliver his keelboat as promised. When he finally was able to take possession of the vessel the morning of August 31, he hastily loaded his cargo of supplies and equipment, brought his temporary 11-man crew aboard and pushed off down the drought-shrunken Ohio River.

Barely three miles from the dock, Lewis brought the keelboat to shore on Brunot's Island where a group of people invited him to stop for a while. The gathering probably included some of his friends and acquaintances. Once ashore he decided to demonstrate the power and accuracy of the air gun he had acquired in Philadelphia. He "charged it [filled the air chamber and loaded it] and fired it myself seven times fifty-five yards with pretty good success." Apparently he then let some of the men try their skill as well. Big mistake!

Obviously shaken, Captain Lewis recorded the subsequent incident in his journal: "Mr. Blaze Cenas being unacquainted with the management of the gun suffered her to discharge herself accidentally [T]he ball passed through the hat of a woman about 40 yards distant cut[t]ing her temple [W]

e were all in the greatest consternation [and] supposed she was dead [I]n a minute she revived to our inexpressible satisfaction, and by examination we found the wound by no means mortal or even dangerous..." Undoubtedly, Lewis would have heaved a nervous sigh of relief upon receiving that diagnosis. He soon thereafter called the crew back aboard the keelboat and proceeded on down the river to his rendezvous with destiny.

Ironically, the Lewis and Clark Expedition began on a note of accidental bloodshed and concluded on a similar note when Private Pierre Cruzatte accidentally shot Captain Lewis in the buttocks while the two were hunting elk in western North Dakota territory barely two months before the expedition ended its historic journey in St. Louis. Truly a curious twist of fate! ■